



The ancient world

For most of the past, people lived as hunter-gatherers. They moved around, hunted animals, and gathered wild plants. After the last Ice Age—a long period of cold weather—ended about 11,500 years ago, people learned how to farm. Planting crops and raising animals meant people had to settle down in one place. The number of people grew, and villages became towns. Soon states and empires were also created.

35,000 years ago

First art

People in Europe and Asia make the first works of art—cave paintings and carvings of animals and people.

5000 BCE

First metal tools

People in Europe and western Asia begin to make tools, such as axes, from copper instead of stone.

4000 BCE

World's first city

Villages at Uruk in Sumer (southern Iraq) join together to create the world's first city.

2613–2503 BCE

Great Pyramids built

Egyptian pharaohs build huge pyramid tombs at Giza.

2500 BCE

Indus cities

The Indus, or Harappan, people build cities in the Indus Valley of northwest India. They also grow cotton for cloth.



Bronze Age spear

2500 BCE

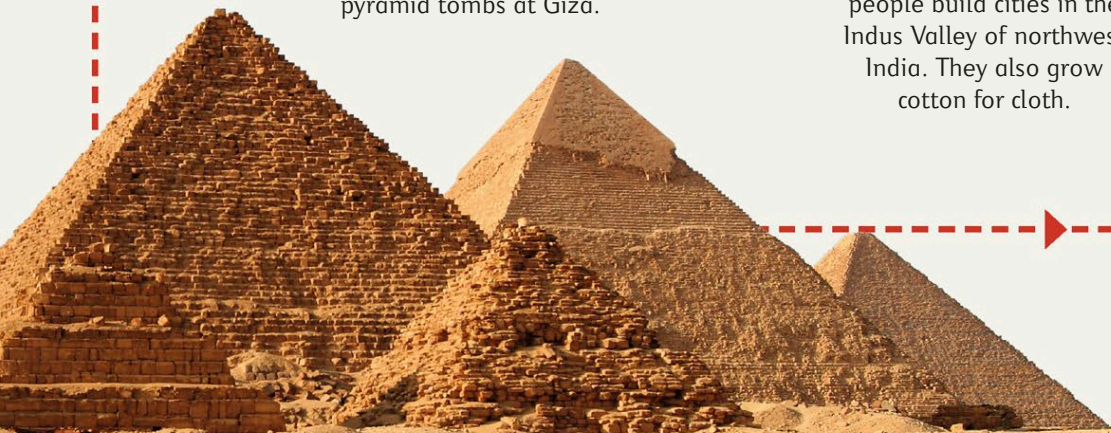
First recorded war

The first recorded war in history is fought, between the Sumerian cities of Lagash and Umma.

c.2300 BCE

First empire

King Sargon of Akkad conquers Mesopotamia and creates the world's first empire.



Pyramids at Giza

117 CE

Roman Empire

The Roman Empire reaches its largest size under Emperor Trajan. It stretches from Spain in the west to Iraq in the east.

221–210 CE

China's first emperor

China is united under the First Emperor. When he dies, he is buried in a tomb protected by a terra-cotta (clay) army.



Terra-cotta army